

PARANOIA

Game Design Document

Busem Deniz

PARANOIA

Game Design Document

Contents Page

1. Game Vision 4

1.1 Vision Statement 4

1.2 Executive Summary 4

1.3 Target Audience 5

1.4 Target Platforms 5

2. Gameplay 6

2.1 Game Loops 6

2.1.1 Main Psychological Loop (Macro Loop) 6

2.1.2 Core Gameplay Loops (Micro Loops) 7

2.1.3 Feedback Loops 8

2.1.4 Loop Stacking 8

2.2 Objectives 9

2.3 Game Progression 9

2.4 Play Flow 10

2.5 Challenge Structure 11

3. Mechanics & Systems 11

3.1 Mechanics, Dynamics & Aesthetics (MDA) 11

3.2 Game Systems 12

3.2.1 Movement 12

3.2.2 Inspection & Interaction 12

3.2.3 Dialogue 13

3.2.4 Panic Management 16

3.3 Game Physics 16

3.4 Player Controls 17

4. Game Economy 17

4.1 Core Resource 17

4.1.1 Composure Values & Thresholds 17

4.2 Accumulation & Recovery Rules 18

4.2.1 Composure Increase 18

4.2.2 Composure Recovery 18

4.2.3 Threshold Effects & Feedback 18

4.3 Breathing Mechanic Integration 19

4.3.1 Trigger Conditions 19
4.3.2 Difficulty Scaling 19
4.3.3 Training Level Application 19
5. Story & Narrative 20
5.1 Narrative Intention 20
5.1.1 Core Themes 20
5.2 The Three-Act Structure 21
5.2.1 Act I – The Ordinary 21
5.2.2 Act II - Escalation 21
5.2.3 Act III - Resolution 22
5.3 Backstory 23
5.4 Characters 23
5.3 Plot Elements 24
5.3.1 World-Building 24
5.3.2 Character-Centric Symbolism 25
5.3.3 Flashback(s) 25
5.3.4 Interface 25
6. Levels 26
6.1 Level Layout 26
6.2.1 Training Level 26
6.2.2 Store Queue 27
6.2.3 Good Samaritan 27
6.2.4 Car Ride 28
6.2.5 Therapy (Good Ending) 28
7. Interface, Visuals & Audio 29
7.1 Menus & Help System 29
7.2 Audio, Music & Sound Effects 30
7.2.1 Diegetic Audio 30
7.2.2 System & Psychological Audio 31
7.3 Art Style 32

PARANOIA

Game Design Document

Game Vision

1.1 Vision Statement

A psychological horror game that challenges the player to question whether the perceived danger is real or a product of fear. Set in a mundane supermarket, the game explores how social pressure and self-doubt can distort judgment where the most dangerous threat becomes the possibility of being right.

1.2 Executive Summary

Paranoia is a narrative-driven psychological horror game inspired by a true story posted online. The player assumes the role of Ashley, a young grocery store worker in the late 1990s, whose ordinary routine escalates into a disturbing encounter with two men. Rather than relying on combat or gore, the game grounds its horror in social pressure, manipulation, and the uncertainty of whether perceived danger is real or imagined.

The game is experienced entirely from a first-person perspective, with all information filtered through Ashley's perception. Gameplay centers on slow exploration and socially driven interaction within a mundane supermarket and its immediate aftermath. The player navigates the environment, inspecting objects to uncover the protagonist's inner thoughts while being drawn into interactions initiated by other characters. Conversations unfold through dialogue choices under social pressure, with key moments shaped by how the player responds to harassment, perceived kindness, and skepticism from others. Player agency is deliberately constrained through lack of combat, sprinting, and a traditional inventory system. These intentional limitations reinforce the themes of vulnerability and entrapment that define the protagonist's psychological state.

Narrative progression is shaped by social decisions rather than skill mastery. Players must interpret ambiguous social cues, decide whom to trust, and choose how to respond under pressure. These choices lead to branching outcomes, including abduction, escape accompanied by disbelief, or unresolved ambiguity. Even when danger appears to be confirmed, the game intentionally undermines certainty, positioning Ashley as an unreliable narrator whose fears are constantly questioned by others.

Visually and structurally, Paranoia adopts a PSX-inspired aesthetic with low-poly models, jitter, and analog distortion. The style anchors the game in its time period while mirroring psychological instability and the imperfect nature of memory and perception. This results in an intimate, unsettling experience that frames horror as something plausibly happening in an ordinary place, to an ordinary person, just out of sight.

1.3 Target Audience

Commented [BD1]: Specify the unique value proposition

The target audience consists of players who enjoy narrative-focused horror experiences, particularly fans of PSX-inspired indie titles such as Fears to Fathom and games by Chilla's Art. The game appeals to players interested in psychological tension, social realism, and emotionally heavy storytelling rather than action or spectacle. While Paranoia contains no gore or explicit blood, due to its mature themes (i.e., harassment, manipulation, panic attacks, implied CSA, and kidnapping), the game is intended for players aged 15 and up who are comfortable engaging with disturbing subject matters.

1.4 Target Platforms

Paranoia is designed primarily for PC (Windows), using mouse and keyboard controls to support precise interaction, dialogue selection, and panic mechanics. The game's scope, control scheme, and visual style are optimized for desktop play with potential for future expansion to other PC-compatible platforms if required.

1.5 Competitive Positioning

Paranoia differentiates itself within the psychological horror genre by shifting the source of fear from external threats to internal interpretation and social ambiguity. Rather than relying on explicit danger, the experience is built around situations that remain plausible, deniable, and socially grounded, forcing the player to question whether perceived threats are real or misinterpreted.

In comparable titles within the genre, horror is often conveyed through a progression from normalcy to explicit danger where the player is gradually led toward a moment of confirmation. Suspense is built through environmental cues, scripted events, and the expectation that a hidden threat will eventually reveal itself in a concrete form.

Paranoia adopts the structural foundation of this genre but diverges in its treatment of tension and resolution. Instead of progressing toward clear confirmation, the game sustains horror through persistent ambiguity. Threats remain socially plausible and interpretable rather than definitively revealed, shifting the focus from discovering danger to questioning whether it exists at all.

Consequently, Paranoia occupies a distinct position within first-person psychological horror by prioritizing interpretation over revelation as its main conflict. The experience is designed not around surviving a known danger, but around enduring uncertainty and the consequences of being unable to fully trust one's own perception.

Gameplay

2.1 Game Loops

Paranoia is structured around a layered loop system where a high-level psychological loop governs multiple smaller, moment-to-moment gameplay loops. These loops are asymmetric by design as they privilege tension accumulation over release and emphasize negative feedback to prevent power fantasy or mastery.

The macro loop reinforces the core theme that threat is rarely confirmed while stress is always real. Each pass through the loop increases doubt while decreasing certainty. Additionally, micro loops operate continuously inside the main psychological loop.

This game loop structure is designed to:

- Maintain psychological pressure without combat
- Replace mastery with vigilance
- Use negative feedback to prevent empowerment
- Align player behavior with Ashley's mental state

By prioritizing regulation over reward, *Paranoia* transforms familiar game loops into tools for psychological horror grounded in social realism.

2.1.1 Main Psychological Loop (Macro Loop)

"Observe ⟶ Interpret ⟶ Face Threat ⟶ Regulate ⟶ Re-engage"

Commented [BD2]: I suppose you mean this is the core theme your loops follow? Usually "macro loop" refers to the wider loop that encompasses the micro loops, rather than referring to a recurring theme.

Commented [BD3R2]: For example, I would imagine your macro loop would be progressing through acts in your story.

1. The player encounters a mundane situation or social interaction.
2. Ambiguous cues trigger interpretation through Ashley's subjective perception.
3. Perceived threat decreases Composure by increasing psychological pressure.
4. The player must regulate stress to maintain agency.
5. Composure is restored, returning the player to observation under heightened sensitivity.

2.1.2 Core Gameplay Loops (Micro Loops)

a. **Inspection (Exploration & Interpretation)**

"Look → Highlighted Object → Inspect → Inner Monologue → Contextual Meaning"

1. Functions as a curiosity-driven loop
2. Provides narrative insight rather than mechanical reward
3. Often decreases Composure, acting as a negative feedback cost for knowledge

b. **Interaction (Commitment)**

"Look → Highlighted Object → Interact → Commit → Action Resolves"

1. Reinforces intentionality and irreversibility
2. No optimization or inventory gain
3. Keeps the player grounded in physical, mundane tasks

c. **Social Pressure & Choice**

"Setup → Dialogue Trigger → Choice Under Pressure → Social Outcome"

1. Choices affect tone, trust, and perceived safety rather than stats
2. Outcomes are often ambiguous
3. Prioritizes emotional consequence over clarity

d. **Panic Management**

"Stress Trigger → Breathing Sequence → Success or Failure → Control or Reset"

1. Acts as a regulation gate, not a punishment

Commented [BD4]: I'm not too sure what this means, why would Composure act as a negative feedback cost for knowledge?

Commented [BD5R4]: Maybe I'm misunderstanding this, since the word "Composure" is usually used to mean something positive.

Commented [BD6]: Perhaps one point you can add per loop is the outcome / motivation - for example, is the main purpose of this to progress the narrative? Since there's no physical gain from it.

2. Failure temporarily removes agency
3. Success restores partial Composure but never fully resets tension

2.1.3 Feedback Loops

Paranoia primarily employs negative feedback loops with limited, localized positive feedback. While the negative feedback loops prevent escalation into mastery and mirror real anxiety spirals, positive feedback is temporary and fragile, never allowing the player to snowball into safety or dominance. In every negative feedback loop, the game pushes back as the player becomes overwhelmed.

Overall, the game loop structure is designed to:

- Maintain psychological pressure without combat
- Replace mastery with vigilance
- Use negative feedback to prevent empowerment
- Align player behavior with Ashley's mental state

By prioritizing regulation over reward, *Paranoia* transforms familiar game loops into tools for psychological horror grounded in social realism.

a. **Negative Feedback Loops (Dominant)**

1. Decreasing Composure increases visual/audio distortion
2. Distortion makes interactions harder to parse
3. Poor parsing decreases Composure further
4. Panic interrupts play, forcing regulation

b. **Positive Feedback Loops (Restricted)**

1. Successful panic regulation restores limited Composure
2. Choosing safe or avoidant dialogue options reduces immediate exposure
3. Creating distance from stressful situations slows Composure loss

2.1.4 Loop Stacking

Unlike traditional games, loops do not resolve cleanly; they recur with variation, reinforcing doubt without allowing the opportunity to have closure. *Paranoia* stacks loops across scales:

1. **Core Loop (seconds-to-seconds):**
   Breathing, dialogue responses, inspections
2. **Scene Loop (minutes):**
   Exploration → confrontation → regulation → relief
3. **Narrative Loop (act-level):**
   Threat implied → denied → partially confirmed → re-framed

Commented [BD7]: Would be great if these are visualized in an actual loop to see how they connect end to end.

2.2 Objectives

a. **Macro**

1. Survive Ashley's shift and post-shift interaction(s) without being taken
2. Navigate social threats while maintaining sufficient Composure
3. Reach one of the narrative conclusions:
   - Taken (bad end)
   - Escaped but disbelieved (ambiguous)

b. **Micro (per segment)**

1. Perform cashier duties.
2. Complete grocery tasks / inspections to understand Ashley.
3. Maintain Composure under stress
4. Manage dialogue with Obnoxious Guy and Charming Guy.
5. Make key decisions: accept/decline escort, choose how to talk to Skylar, etc.

Commented [BD8]: Do tasks only consist of interactions / inspections? Trying to understand how this ties to the loops you mentioned before.

2.3 Game Progression

1. **Training Level** (Register → Aisle → First Flashback)

Establishes routine, constrained agency, and introduces panic management through the first breathing sequence.

2. **Main Grocery Run** (Queue → Charming Guy → Checkout)

Introduces the primary social threats and tests the player's ability to interpret ambiguous intent under pressure.

3. **Good Samaritan Decision** (Exit)
   - **Leave Route (Bad Ending):** Parking lot → panel van reveal → Obnoxious Guy confirmed → abduction cut to black.

- **Stay Route (Main Route):** Bench wait → pager exchange → van observation → Skylar pickup.

4. **Car Ride** (Debrief)

The player shapes how events are described; Skylar challenges Ashley's reliability and interpretation.

5. **Therapy** (Time Skip / Aftermath)

Ashley is framed through external perspectives (Skylar + therapist). A newspaper provides partial confirmation, while the therapist's framing preserves ambiguity over whether the threat was real or perceived.

2.4 Play Flow

1. **Title Screen –** Main Menu: Play Demo, How to Play, Settings, Exit.
2. **Low Stakes Routine** – Cash register tutorial; time pressure is light, tone mundane.
3. **Mild Unease** – Post-shift shopping: slow exploration, internalized loneliness & anxiety.
4. **Confrontation** – Rude customer, control removed → flashback → first Breathing challenge.
5. **Relief** – Co-worker intervention; demo/tutorial arc ends.
6. **Main Threat Setup** – Store queue: Obnoxious Guy intro → insults → Breathing challenge.
7. **False Safety** – Charming Guy "rescues" Ashley; light banter.
8. **Decision Path**:
    - Escort route → slow-burn dread → reveal → hard cut.
    - Stay route → subtle visual cue fades when he leaves → pager & van observation.
9. **Reflection** – Car ride with Skylar: player-voiced version of events.
10. **Doubt** – Therapy office: Skylar + therapist narrate Ashley as unreliable.

11. **Twist** – Newspaper article confirms modus operandi of two-man van scheme; therapist's question undercuts it.
12. **Final Panic** – Ashley hyperventilates; credits over uncertainty.

2.5 Challenge Structure

Challenge is grounded in psychological pressure instead of combat.

- **Mechanical Difficulty**: concentrated into Breathing segments.
- **Cognitive Difficulty**: reading social cues, evaluating trust, parsing incomplete information.
- **Emotional Difficulty**: discomfort in dialogue, being dismissed, morally gray choices.
    - **Failure =** panic collapse or bad narrative ending. Breathing segments reset locally.

Mechanics & Systems

3.1 Mechanics, Dynamics & Aesthetics (MDA)

Paranoia applies the "Mechanics, Dynamics & Aesthetics" (MDA) framework to ensure that psychological tension emerges from player interaction rather than narrative exposition alone. The game's mechanics are designed around restriction, subjectivity, and deliberate commitment, shaping how players move, observe, respond, and cope within ordinary social spaces.

These mechanics give rise to dynamics of hesitation, vigilance, and self-doubt. Restricted movement and grounded interaction slow the player's pace and encourage careful observation rather than impulsive action. Inspection mechanics draw attention to mundane objects, producing reflective play driven by internal interpretation instead of external rewards. Dialogue systems place the player under social pressure, generating uncertainty about how to respond and whether asserting boundaries will escalate or resolve tension. Panic management intermittently disrupts control, reinforcing cycles of stability and collapse that condition players to anticipate anxiety even in non-threatening moments.

Together, these dynamics produce an aesthetic of psychological discomfort grounded in plausibility. The player experiences anxiety through loss of agency, paranoia through ambiguous social cues, and vulnerability through sustained uncertainty rather than explicit threat. By linking restrictive mechanics to dynamics of interpretation and emotional regulation, Paranoia uses the MDA framework to translate internal psychological stress into an interactive experience that is felt through play rather than explained through story.

3.2 Game Systems

3.2.1 Movement

Movement and camera behavior are tuned to support vulnerability. Ashley's base walk speed is modest and cannot be increased; there is no sprint or jump. In certain scenes, movement is deliberately constrained and, in full dialogue or panic sequences, all locomotion is locked. In these constrained segments she is fixed to a spot with head rotation limited to a defined arc, keeping the player anchored to a counter, queue position, or chair. These limits are physically consistent and clearly implied by the environment, and the player is expected to read the restriction itself as narrative: Ashley at work, stuck in line, dissociating, or frozen by anxiety.

3.2.2 Inspection & Interaction

For both inspection and interaction, a central crosshair defines Ashley's focus. When it rests on an interactable object within range, the object emits a yellow emission, a concise on-screen prompt appears, and a brief click sound confirms selection. Only objects surfaced this way can be used; there is no hidden pixel-hunting. Ranges are physically grounded as the player must be within arm's reach and roughly facing the object for the prompt to appear. This prevents snapping to distant targets, preserves the sense of handling real-world space, and reinforces that Ashley only engages with what is close enough to consciously notice.

3.2.2.1 Inspection

Inspection interactions reveal Ashley's inner monologue. Selecting an inspectable object opens a text box containing her thoughts, styled in italics to distinguish them from spoken dialogue. As long as the player keeps the object in view, the text remains; looking away closes it instantly, emphasizing that these thoughts are

momentary and stimulus-bound. Some objects support a second inspection, offering a deeper or more uncomfortable thought if the player persists.

3.2.2.2 Interaction

Interaction is always explicit and intentional. The UI prompts for interactable objects change depending on the action (e.g. “Ring”, “Collect”, “Read”). Once committed, the action resolves reliably and may advance the scene, branch dialogue, or subtly adjust tension. Instances are listed below.

- Processing customer items at the register → “Ring” (Training Level)
- Bagging purchased groceries at checkout → “Collect” (Store Queue)
- Committing to remaining in the store or leaving with Charming Guy → “Stay” or “Leave” (Good Samaritan)
- Picking up and reading newspaper in the therapist’s office → “Read” (Therapy)

3.2.3 Dialogue

When a conversation begins, free movement is suspended and a dialogue box appears. If no choices are present, the player advances each line with a left click; text never auto-advances without their input. When choices are available, the player selects one with the cursor and confirms with a click, which may influence tone, relationship, or outcome. Ashley’s spoken lines appear as standard text under her name; her unspoken reactions remain italic, preserving the distinction between what she says and what she cannot.

3.2.3.1 Dialogue Example

Skylar: Did you get all your bags?

Ashley: Not like I had much to buy.

(Skylar gives Ashley a look.)[1]

Ashley: Yeah. I got everything.

(Beat.)

Skylar: So. What happened?

[1] Parentheses denote actions or beats during which the dialogue text box temporarily disappears.

Player choices:

A. What do you mean?

B. There was this guy…

C. I felt sick.

Choice A – What do you mean?

Ashley: What do you mean?

Skylar: You paged me to leave work early and drive across town. So, I'm asking… /n[2] …what… /n …happened.

Ashley: I'm… sorry.

(Skylar glances at Ashley.)

Skylar: … n/ It's fine. I just wanted to know if you're sick, something happened at work, or whatever. You know I'll come get you regardless.

Player choices:

A. *Tell Skylar what happened* → go to Choice B – There was this guy…

B. *Make up an excuse* → go to Choice C – I felt sick.

Choice B – There was this guy…

Ashley: There was this guy.

Skylar: Of course.

Ashley: I was in line and he went /n "I LIKE YOUR HAIR!" n/ F*cking embarrassing. Then he started insulting me out of nowhere. Going about me being a bitch and all that.

Skylar: F*cking dick.

(Skylar slaps the steering wheel with the bottom of her palm.)

Skylar: I swear, half these guys should be on leashes. n/ What happened after?

Player choices:

A. Then this other guy…

B. I paged you.

B1 – Then this other guy…

[2] "/n" denotes that the following text is displayed in a new text box in-game.

Ashley: Then this other guy stepped in. Told him to back off. He actually left.

Skylar: Good. Ashley: And then the other guy offered to walk me out. To the bus stop. He was… nice.

(Beat.)

Ashley: I said yes. Then I got this feeling and told him never mind.

(Skylar glances at her.)

Skylar: Well… I get you'd be jumpy after the first creep. But I mean…

Ashley: What? Skylar: You get a 'gut feeling' about every guy, Ash. I never know when it's intuition talking or… /n your paranoia.

(Beat.)

Ashley: It wasn't paranoia. I saw him walk to this van. Someone else was waiting in the driver's seat. That's- that's weird, right?

Skylar: So what? Bus stop's a five-minute walk from there. Maybe his ride was picking him up. Maybe it's his carpool. Not every van is a kidnapping.

Player choices:

A. *Argue*

B. *Accept*

B1a – *Argue*

Ashley: But-

Skylar: Ash, can we not do that right now? We'll talk at home.

Ashley: Okay. Fine. Sorry.

(Dialogue ends.)

B1b – Accept

Ashley: … /n Yeah. Maybe I just… freaked myself out.

Skylar: There you go.

(Dialogue ends.)

B2 – I paged you.

Ashley: I paged you.

Skylar: I know that part.

(Beat.)

Skylar: I'm asking what happened before that. Like, did you just turn away and page me?

Ashley: I... He… The cashier told him not to hold the line and I paged you while she ranged me. It was either that or… black out. I couldn't breathe.

Skylar: Okay. Then you did the right thing.

Choice C – I felt sick.

Ashley: I felt sick. Like, nauseous. Couldn't take the bus.

Skylar: Well, do you feel better now?

Ashley: …I guess.

Skylar: You know, a therapist could help with that as well.

Ashley: With what?

Skylar: The panic. The food thing. You don't eat meat, fine. Triggering or whatever. But you don't eat much of anything either.

Ashley: …

Skylar: You can't 'not be hungry' every day. That's not how bodies work.

Ashley: Can we not do this right now? I really don't feel well.

Skylar: Fine. Starve yourself. See how that works out.

3.2.4 Panic Management

Panic sequences translate Ashley's anxiety into a mechanical test. When triggered, the vignette tightens, sound narrows, and a "Breathe" prompt appears alongside a focus bar, signaling her mind locking onto a single vital action. The player must rapidly click to push the bar to completion; pausing or slowing allows it to drain. Success restores normal vision and control, while failure results in a brief faint and a reset of the scene. The system reinforces that managing her panic is essential to maintaining agency, attention, and narrative momentum.

3.3 Game Physics

At the store, where all movement sequences take place, collisions are simple and readable, using physical design instead of invisible walls to define boundaries. Shelves, counters, turnstiles, and NPCs act as solid barriers, while narrow aisles and queue rails naturally funnel the player along intended paths. The player cannot clip through other

characters; being forced to stand behind them in line or remain fixed in front of them during dialogues reinforce social pressure and the feeling of limited escape.

Time behaves realistically by default: animations, ambient loops, and NPC idles run at normal speed, keeping the space grounded and ordinary. When flashbacks or panic spikes occur, perceived time distorts through visual effects and audio design without altering the underlying simulation. The world keeps moving while Ashley's perception warps.

3.4 Player Controls

- WASD – Move
- Mouse – Look
- LMB – Interact / advance text / confirm
- ESC – Pause menu, settings

Crosshair visible in free-movement segments; hidden or repurposed in cinematics.

Game Economy

Commented [BD9]: If there's waiting or going slow for Composure to regulate, it would affect playtime. Would love to see how it affects overall playtime estimates, perhaps in numbers and ideally represented in a graph or diagram. Perhaps a sample scenario / snippet of the game can be portrayed that way for us to understand better with the added perspective of time.

4.1 Core Resource

Composure represents the protagonist's ability to remain mentally regulated in social and environmental situations. Unlike traditional health systems, Composure does not represent physical damage, but cumulative psychological strain. The system functions as a continuous resource the player must actively manage to maintain agency.

Composure is displayed as an omnipresent UI bar, remaining visible across all gameplay segments to reinforce constant psychological pressure. The system functions as:

- A resource economy, not a punishment system
- A pacing controller that discourages rapid, exhaustive interaction
- A psychological analogue to health systems without physical violence

Making Composure omnipresent and slow to recover positions stress as a persistent, accumulating presence that is subtle yet enduring, and ultimately something to cope with rather than resolve.

4.1.1 Composure Values & Thresholds

- **Range:** 0–100

- **Optimal Zone:** 80–100
- **Elevated Zone:** 60–80
- **Critical Zone:** 80–100

Composure does not reset between encounters within a level. Instead, it persists and accumulates, reinforcing the idea that stress compounds instead of disappearing instantly.

4.2 Accumulation & Recovery Rules

4.2.1 Composure Decrease

Composure decreases through:

- Triggering inspections (objects with distressing internal monologue)
- Social confrontations
- Consecutive stressful interactions without recovery time
- Remaining in confined or socially pressuring spaces

Certain interactions are tagged as High-Impact Triggers, causing faster Composure gain when chained together.

4.2.2 Composure Recovery

Composure naturally recovers over time when the player is given space:

- Avoiding interaction
- Moving through low-pressure areas
- After completing a successful breathing sequence

Recovery is intentionally slower than accumulation to discourage brute-force play and promote pacing.

Commented [BD10]: Great intent. Concerned it might be a bit slow and boring but it depends on the cognitive / mental decision load while waiting.

4.2.3 Threshold Effects & Feedback

a. **Elevated Zone (60–80)**

- Subtle screen noise
- Mild chromatic aberration
- Slight audio dampening
- Faster Composure gain from new triggers

This zone signals rising instability without removing player control.

b. **Critical Zone (80–100)**

- Heavy visual distortion
- Vignette tightening
- Increased breathing audio
- Input latency during interactions

Crossing into this zone immediately arms a panic trigger, meaning the next qualifying stressor will initiate a breathing sequence.

Visually, this mirrors traditional health systems where danger is communicated through audiovisual degradation rather than numeric failure.

4.3 Breathing Mechanic Integration

4.3.1 Trigger Conditions

During free-play segments where the player moves without immediate narrative constraints, breathing sequences function as regulation checks rather than binary fail states, contrasting with their role in scripted encounters.

Overall, they can be triggered in three ways:

1. Scripted narrative moments
2. Entering the Critical Zone and encountering an additional stressor
3. Forced early triggers during training scenarios

4.3.2 Difficulty Scaling

- **Training Breathing Sequences**: Triggered earlier, easier to complete, and recover less Composure
- **Standard Breathing Sequences**: Triggered at high Composure, require sustained input, restore more Composure

Failure results in a brief dissociative collapse and scene reset, reinforcing the cost of poor regulation.

4.3.3 Training Level Application

During the training section, Composure is intentionally tuned to be volatile:

- Triggering inspections increase Composure faster than it can decay
- Early breathing sequences are triggered at lower thresholds
- Visual distortion appears sooner but fades faster

This teaches the player that internal thoughts are mechanically dangerous, stress is not tied only to overt threats and that regulation is an active skill, not a passive state.

Story & Narrative

5.1 Narrative Intention

Paranoia is designed as a psychological horror game that explores fear, perception, and the social consequences of being wrong or worse, being right.

There are no monsters to defeat and no clear villains to expose. The danger is ordinary, socially acceptable, and difficult to name. It appears as a compliment, a helpful gesture, a calm voice offering reassurance. Nothing is overtly wrong, yet something never fully feels right.

The tension does not revolve around whether a threat exists. It revolves around whether Ashley can trust herself when that threat cannot be immediately proven. Every interaction forces her to choose between instinct and social harmony, between discomfort and the fear of being mistaken.

What begins as an attempt to leave safely becomes something more corrosive. Ashley has been conditioned to soften her reactions, to reinterpret unease as misunderstanding, to doubt her body before she doubts others. The deeper conflict lies in whether she can resist that reflex.

The story avoids clean resolution. Even when danger is confirmed, relief is complicated. Even when danger is avoided, doubt remains. Certainty never arrives without consequence.

At its core, *Paranoia* is about the cost of self-erasure. Fear can be endured. Losing faith in your own perception is far more dangerous.

5.1.1 Core Themes

- Perception of Reality
- Fear & Isolation
- Trust in Oneself

- Self-Erasure
- Power Imbalance

5.2 The Three-Act Structure

Commented [BD11]: This is really good stuff. Well structured, nice and clear and good use of frameworks. I like how you clearly lay out your themes, and talk about how your player experiences them. There's probably a bit too much detail in the three-act structure segment for this kind of document. Condensing that stuff down will make it more digestable to readers.

5.2.1 Act I – The Ordinary

a) Exposition

Ashley finishes her shift behind the cash register, moving through repetitive tasks under harsh fluorescent lighting. Behind the counter, the store feels safe. Customers approach, transact, and leave, and her role provides a clear structure for interaction.

Once her shift ends, she remains in uniform and begins shopping. Without the barrier of the counter, the space feels subtly different. It's more open. More exposed… Her groceries reflect routine rather than care, and she avoids certain sections without fully questioning why. Ashley seeks stability above all else, believing that by staying agreeable and unremarkable, she can prevent situations from escalating.

b) Inciting Incident

Near the end of an aisle, a regular customer approaches and asks for help, assuming she is still working. She explains that her shift has ended, expecting the interaction to resolve, but it does not. His tone shifts from polite to irritated, his presence becoming just uncomfortable enough to feel wrong without clearly justifying confrontation.

Ashley hesitates. Asserting herself would require certainty; escalating would require proof. Instead, she softens her response and apologizes. As the interaction stretches, her perception begins to fracture. Her breathing shortens, the environment tightens, and a familiar unease intrudes. Before the moment fully escalates, a co-worker intervenes and the situation dissolves. To anyone else, it was insignificant. For Ashley, it lingers.

c) Plot Point One

Ashley has the option to leave the store immediately, but instead chooses to stay. She joins the checkout line as a customer, now without the protection of her role or the barrier of the counter. The environment remains unchanged, yet her sense of safety has already shifted.

5.2.2 Act II - Escalation

a) Rising Action

While waiting in line, Ashley becomes the focus of another man whose behavior escalates from intrusive attention to hostility. The interaction remains socially ambiguous, but the public setting traps her in place, increasing pressure. When she does not reciprocate, his tone turns accusatory, drawing attention from others.

Another man intervenes, presenting himself as calm and considerate, causing the first to withdraw. The situation appears resolved, but the sense of safety is unstable. The threat divides into two forms: one overt and aggressive, the other subtle and controlled. The second man offers to help and suggests walking her out, framing his behavior as reasonable and safe.

b) Midpoint

If Ashley accepts, the encounter continues into the parking lot, where the environment remains outwardly ordinary while the path gradually shifts away from safety. A white van comes into view, and the earlier aggressor reappears, revealing coordination.

If she refuses, she later observes the same connection from inside the store, watching the two men leave together. In both cases, the illusion of safety collapses. Being wrong carries social consequences, but being right carries physical risk.

c) Plot Point Two

During the car ride with Skylar, Ashley must recount the event. Her experience is questioned, reframed, and partially dismissed, shifting the conflict away from the external threat and toward her own interpretation.

Ashley must decide how much of the event to disclose and how to frame it. Was it a coincidence, or something coordinated? Was it fear, or pattern recognition? Up until now, she has survived by minimizing her experiences. In this moment, she is forced to decide whether to continue doing so.

5.2.3 Act III - Resolution

If Ashley left with the guy, the story ends in the parking lot. The van door opens, and the screen cuts to black.

If she stayed in the grocery story, the confrontation shifts inward.

a) Pre-Climax

In the therapist's office, Ashley's experience is interpreted through the perspectives of others. Skylar and the therapist frame her reactions through anxiety and past trauma,

subtly undermining her certainty. The threat is no longer defined by the event itself, but by the ambiguity surrounding it.

b) Climax

The story concludes without resolution. The threat may have been real, but certainty is never fully achieved. The absence of immediate danger does not restore safety; instead, it leaves Ashley in a state where both interpretations coexist. Doubt lingers, unresolved, even in silence.

c) Denouement

The session ends without breakthrough. Outside, the night is still. No vans idle at the curb, no footsteps trail behind her… The world presents no immediate threat.

Ashley sits alone in Skylar's apartment, the silence heavier than the noise ever was. The kidnapping scheme was real. Her trauma is real. Both can exist, yet neither resolves the other. Certainty does not arrive, and it never fully does.

She does not apologize for what she felt, nor does she retract what she saw. Still, doubt remains. It's quiet, persistent, and unresolved. For the first time, she cannot tell whether the absence of danger is safety, or simply a pause.

5.3 Backstory

Ashley grew up under a manipulative, abusive male authority figure, leaving her with unresolved trauma and a constant low-level sense of threat. As an adult, she maintains a functional but hollow routine, living in a cheap apartment and working at a local grocery store. Skylar, her high-achieving friend, supports her but is exhausted by the emotional weight. Ashley's anxiety leaks into avoidance of men, disordered eating, and a sharp panic whenever she feels watched, cornered, or "rude" for rejecting advances.

5.4 Characters

1. **Ashley**

   Playable protagonist. Store worker in her mid-20s. Quiet, hypervigilant, clever but self-erasing. Her inner thoughts are articulate while her spoken lines are hesitant and timid. Her disrupted perception of reality is visually mirrored in the world through glitches and vignettes.

2. **Skylar**

   Ashley's best friend. Financial analyst in her mid-20's. Assertive, pragmatic, over-functioning. Loves Ashley but communicates in ultimatums and fixes.

Reads as both protective and controlling. Brushes off Ashley's anxiety as paranoia and pushes her to get professional treatment.

3. **Obnoxious Guy**

   Main antagonist. In his late 30s. Loud, entitled, self-proclaimed "nice guy." Knows no boundaries and uses the whole store as his stage. Represents obvious danger.

4. **Charming Guy**

   Passer-by who intervenes. In his late 20s. Soft-spoken and attentive, portrays himself as a genuine gentleman. Represents ambiguous danger; visually clean and polite, but framed with subtle depravity.

5. **Rude Customer**

   Middle-aged regular who misreads Ashley's uniform and pushes past her boundaries to receive servility. His mundane hostility triggers disproportionate panic for Ashley.

6. **Store Employee**

   Co-worker who cuts in briefly to confirm Ashley is off the clock and deescalate the situation with Rude Customer. A decent interaction that forces the player to question whether every man is a threat, or filtered through Ashley's fear.

7. **Therapist**

   Male CBT therapist booked by Skylar. In Ashley's eyes, he's positioned between genuine help and institutional gaslighting. His clinical questioning in the wake of the incident risks reframing Ashley's fear as pathology rather than response.

5.3 Plot Elements

5.3.1 World-Building

Ashley's surroundings and inner dialogue subtly reveal her mental state, personal history and the era she inhabits.

Store Items:

- Microwave Chilli → Low-care self-maintenance; burnout and neglect.
- Meat → Has an eating disorder connected to trauma of abuse

- Beer → Medicalized anxiety; suggests history of panic attacks.
- Chips → Lives alone / no shared domestic life + defensive "at least I don't have to share" = loneliness masked as choice.

Era Indicators (late 1990s):

- Manual Cash Register → Lacks a barcode scanner, requiring Ashley to input prices manually; emphasizes the pre-digital retail world.
- Pager → Replaces a cell phone; symbolizes limited connectivity and signals Ashley's lower-income status.
- Car Radio → Has the distinct 90s analog sound quality, playing contemporary pop hits.

Pager Codes:

- 91120 → 911 = "Call back now", 20 = "Where are you"; together implies "pick me up now"
- 104 → "Okay/Affirmative"

5.3.2 Character-Centric Symbolism

- Restricted movement during selected scenes → A visual metaphor for habitual vigilance without power. Frames Ashley's lack of agency in a situation she is physically and psychologically confined.
- Charming Guy helping bag groceries → Performs tenderness, mirrors predator grooming.
- Chromatic aberration around Charming Guy → Visualized intuition that something's off.
- Skylar minimizing gut feeling → Reinforces theme that no one takes Ashley perception fully seriously.
- Therapist office with Skylar oversharing → Institutional gaze on Ashley's trauma; she's objectified even in "help."

5.3.3 Flashback(s)

- Overlapping present environment & flashback → Blurred reality; Ashley's emotional truth is intrusive and inescapable, regardless of setting.
- Hyperventilation vignette / focus shifts → Somatic horror; body hijacks control.
- Larger man, reaching camera → Power imbalance, grooming, bodily threat.

5.3.4 Interface

- Dialogue options shrinking to "…" → Mechanically enforces Ashley silencing.

- Breathing sequence text “Breathe” → Ashley’s brain going into survival mode, hyper fixated on one vital thing.

Levels

6.1 Level Layout

Commented [BD12]: Are black circles NPCs? I think I see a steering wheel, I suppose they're in a car?

Do also try to find a way to label those areas as it might be clear to you, but it takes some time for me to figure them out - e.g. store, carpark, car

Also, where would the store queue be? Do NPCs wander around the store or just stand in line?

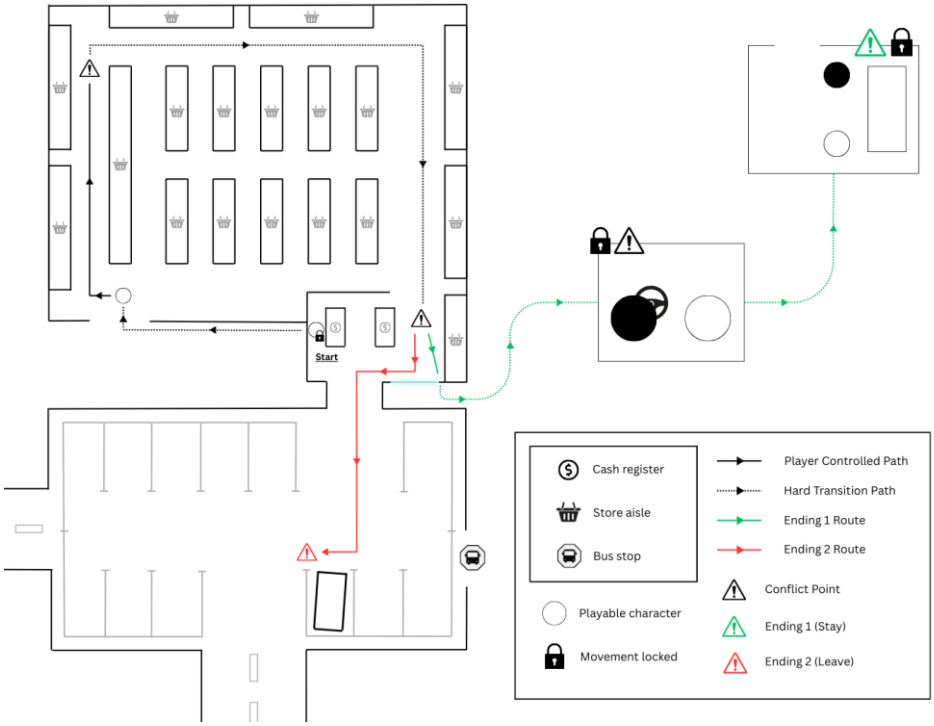


Figure 1. Diagram showing player spawns, movement restrictions, conflict points, and branching routes leading to different narrative outcomes.

6.2.1 Training Level

The game opens with Ashley at the cash register, closing out her shift, her brief inner thoughts signaling exhaustion from working. After the supervisor releases her, she moves through the store to pick up some groceries, her quiet observations of products and surroundings reflecting how she lives.

Near the aisle’s end, a regular customer misreads her as still on the clock and presses her for assistance. Ashley’s inability to assert that she is off-duty, combined with his growing

irritation, escalates into a brief traumatic intrusion from her past. The sequence crests in a controlled panic episode which she must overcome before a co-worker intervenes and the encounter breaks.

6.2.2 Store Queue

Commented [BD13]: These are all great and engaging. I wonder how long your game will last? It doesn't seem like there's a lot of content. Perhaps you can detail that in the Economy/Playtime section in the future.

Ashley joins the checkout line with her groceries, boxed in by other customers and slow movement forward. A man lingering nearby fixates on her, later to be referred as "Obnoxious Guy." The interaction starts with loud compliments that quickly become invasive, public, and relentless. Ashley's attempts to respond or deflect are gradually overridden as he dominates the exchange, culminating in a hostile outburst when she does not reciprocate his advances.

The public tension and scrutiny trigger another panic episode; if she manages to contain it, a man behind her intervenes, calls out the behavior, and Obnoxious Guy withdraws. The intervening stranger, "Charming Guy," is left framed as considerate and steady, his presence quietly set up for the following sequence.

6.2.3 Good Samaritan

In the uneasiness that follows, Ashley pays for her groceries, still preoccupied by the possibility of Obnoxious Guy waiting outside, and asks the cashier whether someone from staff can walk her to the bus stop. Charming Guy stays close, helps bag her items, and offers to escort her himself so she does not have to leave alone. Ashley initially agrees. The exchange reads as plausible kindness in an unchanged mundane environment and leads directly into the pivotal decision at the store's exit.

a) Leave (Bad Ending)

If Ashley follows through and leaves with him, she and Charming Guy exit into a mostly empty parking lot. He carries her bags, keeps conversation light, and gradually leads her off the natural path toward a white panel van under the pretext of retrieving his jacket. The bus stop remains visible, but the route bends away from it in small, seemingly reasonable steps. When he opens the van door and the interior light flicks on, Obnoxious Guy is revealed in the driver's seat; Ashley is forced into the vehicle as the scene cuts abruptly to black. This path provides a concise abduction ending that confirms the threat pattern without prolonging play.

b) Stay (Main Route)

If Ashley reconsiders, she chooses to remain in the store and wait for a ride. Depending on whether she invokes a fiancé or simply mentions a friend,

Charming Guy either backs off quickly or makes a final round of polite insistence before accepting her refusal and leaving. Once alone, Ashley sits near the front with a view of the lot and her pager in hand. Watching from inside, she sees the same man join someone waiting in a white van before they drive off. A short-coded exchange with her friend, Skylar, confirms that she is on her way. The level closes with Ashley's choice validated indirectly: the danger is acknowledged through observation rather than impact.

6.2.4 Car Ride

Skylar picks Ashley up and drives her home. The entire sequence is contained within the car, focusing on a dialogue in which Ashley can choose how much of the evening to disclose and how to frame it. Skylar's reactions oscillate between care, impatience, and skepticism, subtly reframing events the player has witnessed as exaggeration, familiar pattern, or genuine concern. The scene positions the core tension between Ashley's internal reality and how those around her interpret it, while maintaining continuity of her single, constrained viewpoint.

6.2.5 Therapy (Good Ending)

Later, Ashley waits in a therapist's office with Skylar. Before the therapist arrives, a strained exchange makes clear that Skylar arranged the session after Ashley quit her job, stopped eating properly, and became financially dependent on her in the aftermath of the incident. When the therapist enters, Ashley avoids eye contact as Skylar takes the lead, outlining Ashley's trauma history and recent behavior, effectively speaking for her, while the environment offers limited focal points to break up the monologue.

A newspaper on the table reveals a reported two-man "Good Samaritan" kidnapping scheme that closely aligns with the supermarket incident, giving external weight to Ashley's perspective. When she tries to voice that connection, the therapist cuts her off with a measured response, reframing it as an open question: predators or projection? This prompts a final surge of panic in which Charming Guy's polite smile and the therapist's professionalism blur together as different faces of the same concealed threat. The game ends in that unresolved space, with confirmation and doubt coexisting rather than neatly resolved.

Interface, Visuals & Audio

7.1 Menus & Help System

The game includes a Main Menu and Pause Menu. Main menu appears over a static supermarket aisle shot, occasionally interrupted by a brief glitched flash of a fallen basket and spilled items, foreshadowing unease. Options for the main menu are “Play Demo”, “How to Play”, “Settings”, and “Exit”.



Figure 2. *Mockups of the animated* ***Main Menu****, displayed over a static supermarket aisle background. A briefly glitching fallen shopping basket appears intermittently, foreshadowing unease and establishing the game’s tone. Made on Unity.*

Pressing ESC in-game opens a pause menu that freezes gameplay, overlays the scene with a darkened filter, and displays a compact pixelated panel with “Resume”, “Settings”, and “Exit”.

“How to Play” functions as a help system, presenting a concise overview of controls (WASD, mouse look, interact/advance, pause) and core interaction expectations to the player.



Figure 3. *Mockups of the* ***How to Play*** *section, including an overview of player controls and an example sequence explaining the “Breathe” mechanic. Made on Canvas.*

Settings accessed from either menu provide basic configuration, including separate sliders for ambient/world audio and UI/system sounds, using the same visual style as dialogue buttons to maintain consistency.

7.2 Audio, Music & Sound Effects

Audio is predominantly diegetic, low-key, and textured to reinforce the grounded horror tone. Music and sound are used sparingly to track Ashley's stress, guide focus, and blur the line between normalcy and threat.

7.2.1 Diegetic Audio

The supermarket environment is characterized by a persistent layer of mundane, low-level sounds that establish familiarity before being weaponized, such as:

- Constant refrigerator hums
- Distant PA announcements
- HVAC noise
- Flickering fluorescent lights form a sterile acoustic backdrop

At the cash register, multi-key typing loops accompany item processing, remaining distinct from interface clicks to preserve immersion. Three variations of in-store background music provide light, period-appropriate ambience that grows subtly darker and thinner as tension escalates.

During queue and harassment sequences, the same store ambience becomes increasingly oppressive. Background music dulls and thins, while environmental sound gradually muffles, reflecting Ashley's narrowing focus and rising panic as social pressure intensifies.

In the car ride sequence on the stay route, audio shifts to an enclosed, transitional soundscape. The sequence includes:

- Engine noise
- Tires on asphalt
- Passing traffic

These sounds dominate the mix, accompanied by low-volume late-1990s pop music played through a cheap, slightly tinny radio. The familiar sound reinforces a sense of temporary safety while remaining emotionally detached.

The therapist's office contrasts this with quiet institutional stillness. A slow clock tick and faint elevator music bleeding in from the hallway emphasize discomfort, passivity, and the clinical framing of Ashley's experience.

In the parking lot and van sequence on the leave route, audio becomes sparse and exposed. Distant traffic, occasional wildlife, and footsteps on asphalt heighten isolation. This restraint culminates in a sudden, abrupt sequence of sounds:

- The van door opening
- Interior light flicking on
- A brief vocal reaction (i.e. “Ah!”)
- A hard door slam ending the scene.

7.2.2 System & Psychological Audio

System audio is intentionally kept minimal and consistent. A single, subdued UI click is used across interactions, including inspection confirmations and dialogue advancement, ensuring functional clarity without drawing attention away from the environment.

Panic sequences introduce a distinct psychological audio layer. Ambient sound becomes muffled, the stereo field tightens, and heightened breathing and pulse-like swells synchronize with visual vignettes. On failure, a brief distorted audio drop signals collapse before the scene resets, reinforcing the physical and emotional consequences of losing control.

Flashbacks and intuition cues are marked by short, intrusive audio elements such as glitch bursts, filtered noise, and a subtly distorted male laugh. These cues are used sparingly to avoid desensitization, serving as auditory markers of intrusive memory or sensed wrongness rather than explicit threat.

7.3 Art Style

a) Aesthetic Foundation

The visual identity of Paranoia is rooted in PSX-inspired aesthetics, using low poly models with visible seams, stretched UVs, and rough geometry. Textures are hand-painted at low resolution with light dithering, reinforcing a sense of imperfection and instability that aligns with Ashley's fractured perception.



*Figure 4. Visual references shown in order: **Nightlink** (1998), **Back in 1995** (2016), **Threshold** (2022) and **Carson House – Fears to Fathom** (2021).*

b) Lighting & Atmosphere

Lighting is intentionally harsh and unsettling. Fluorescent overexposure and sharp shadow falloff create a sterile, hostile environment while flat, specular lighting replaces dynamic reflections to heighten artificiality and emotional numbness. The space feels functional rather than comforting, mirroring Ashley's psychological detachment.





Figure 5. *Supermarket scenes shown in order:* ***The Supermarket Horror*** *(2021),* ***Heavy Rain*** *(2010),* ***Fears to Fathom – Carson House*** *(2021), and* ***Dead of Night: Supermarket*** *(2022).*

c) Post-Processing & Visual Effects

Post-processing effects are applied with restraint and purpose. Subtle chromatic aberration, screen jitter, and frame instability communicate psychological strain without overwhelming the image. These effects intensify dynamically in response to anxiety, evolving from mild desaturation into temporal blur and peripheral distortion during heightened stress.



Figure 6. *Chromatic aberration and screen jitter examples.*

d) Color Palette

The color palette is dominated by washed-out beige, gray, and cold white tones that reflect the sterility of the supermarket setting. Warm hues appear briefly during moments of perceived comfort or safety which then fade back into desaturated neutrality as doubt resurfaces.

e) Interface Integration

Interface elements are integrated as narrative devices wherever possible. Traditional HUD elements are replaced by in-world text overlays, flickering signage, and ambient cues, maintaining stylistic and psychological consistency between environment, interface, and narrative experience.

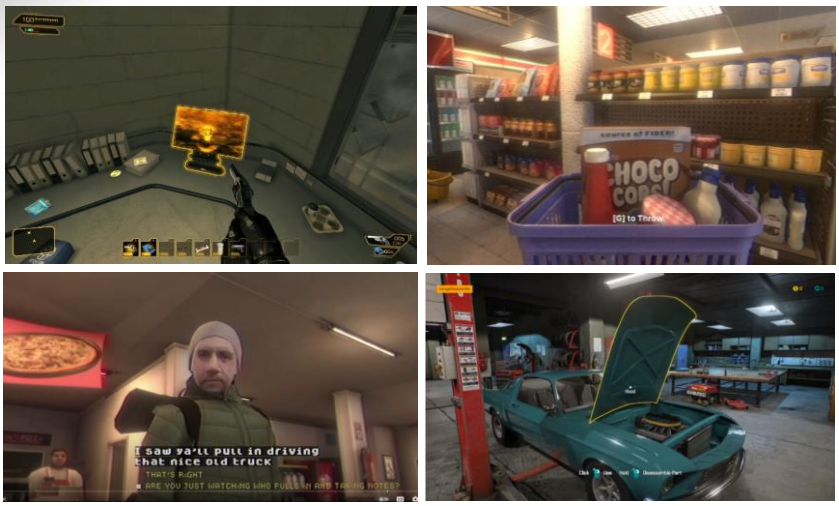


Figure 7. *In-world interface and HUD examples shown in order:* ***Deus Ex: Human Revolution*** *(2011),* ***Fears to Fathom – Carson House*** *(2021),* ***Fears to Fathom – Norwood Hitchhike*** *(2023), and* ***Car Mechanic Simulator*** *(2018).*